



The Propagator

The Monthly Newsletter of the South Orange Amateur Radio Association

September 2026

South Orange Amateur Radio Association | Editor: Ray Frericks, K6NOV

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Upcoming SOARA Events

This Month — September 2026

Date	Time	Event	Location
Saturday, September 19	9:00 AM–noon	SOARA Elmer Saturday	Gilleran Park
Monday, September 21	6:00 PM	Ham Radio License Exams	Murray Center
Monday, September 21	6:30 PM	Membership Meeting	Murray Center
Monday, September 28	7:00 PM	Board Meeting	Murray Center

Next Month — October 2026

Date	Time	Event	Location
Saturday, October 17	9:00 AM–noon	SOARA Elmer Saturday	Gilleran Park
Monday, October 19	6:00 PM	Ham Radio License Exams	Murray Center
Monday, October 19	6:30 PM	Membership Meeting	Murray Center
Monday, October 26	7:00 PM	Board Meeting	Murray Center

Dates, locations, and times are subject to change. Check the [SOARA website](#) before attending.

President's Message

SOARA held its annual summer picnic on August 22 at Laguna Niguel Regional Park. It was a warmish day, but there was a good breeze and we stayed comfortable under the picnic shelter. I want to thank all of the SOARA members and their families who came out to enjoy a day in the park. If you missed the picnic this year, I hope you are able to attend in 2027.

September is National Preparedness Month and I want to talk a little bit about what that means in the context of our hobby. Amateur radio is the only means of instant communications where both ends of the conversation do not need any external resources to make it happen. We can run our stations on batteries, use a portable antenna and generally set up anywhere to provide communications services. HF communications can directly span longer distances to places outside the immediate disaster area, which no other service can reliably provide. So, it would seem that we might plan to be called upon to provide those services for local governments and agencies in the case of a large scale disaster. Out here in California, that would likely be an earthquake or perhaps a tsunami. While that might be one possibility for using our skill and Amateur radio license to help, there are many others, including Health and Welfare traffic from your neighbors. Don't underestimate the value of being able to provide a way for your neighbors to tell their families in other states they are OK, when all cell service is disrupted and the internet is down for a week or more.

However, take a step back and ask yourself, am I and my family capable of being self-sufficient for a week or more? After all, you can't help others until you and everyone around you are safe, have food and water, medicines and some shelter from the elements. Starting from a position of safety, you can then go help others. RACES/ARES train that the first step after any disaster occurs is to make sure you and your family are safe before considering deployment to help others.

There are many checklists and other guides to preparing for various scenarios. I'd suggest looking at resources from ARRL or FEMA to get a start on making your own list. You should have a set of supplies for your home that will sustain you for at least a week minimum, 2 weeks would be better. You should also have a kit for one of your cars and keep that car's fuel tank or battery at least half full at all times. If you often travel a significant distance from home for work, plan to have some supplies in a second car if you get stranded away from home, with the primary vehicle at home available to leave if the disaster places it at risk. I am probably repeating many things you have heard before, but if you have not actually made a plan, now is the time to do that.

Our meeting in September will have several local ham groups that will talk about how they drill for emergencies and what kinds of other activities they do to help the community. The best way to be prepared is to train and plan with one of those groups. I hope you will be able to attend the September meeting and hear what these groups have to say.

On another topic, I wanted to mention something that happened recently. While we were conducting one of our Tuesday night VHF/UHF nets, a participant had to interrupt his transmission because a LiMnO pack had caught fire and was making some smoke and heat. He used a fire extinguisher to try and put out the fire, which may have self extinguished. It turns out that the fire extinguisher would have been helpful to put out the fire on/in other objects ignited by the battery, but the extinguisher would have little effect on the lithium battery. Battery fires are very hard to put out because they are often sealed units armored from direct contact with extinguishing agents and they generate massive quantities of their own heat. If you have a battery fire, especially a lithium battery fire, the best way to make it safe is to place the battery in a metal bucket filled with fine sand and then carry it outside. The sand may partially smother the flames and will also insulate the surroundings from the heat.

I had a similar problem with a very small lithium battery (800mAh) that started to heat up and eventually melted the wires going to the device, all while laying in my hand. I suspect the supply leads shorted, but I got a nice burned strip on my hand before I dropped it in a bucket.

The take-away here is that if you are working with batteries, have a plan about what you are going to do if the pack or wiring catches fire. A metal bucket with sand is one idea. A non-conductive non-flammable surface is another. Either way you want the whole mess outside and well away from the house and other important objects.

One final reminder. SOARA dues are due on October 1st of each year. We will be sending out a notice via email to all members. Thanks for your continued support of SOARA.

Stay safe and I look forward to hearing you on the air or seeing you at a meeting.

73,

Dale Tyler, W6EDT
SOARA President

SOARA Saturday Report

The last SOARA Saturday was August 15, 2026, at Gilleran Park. The theme was battery boxes and connector boxes. Greg, N6PM, brought donuts. We broke even on donut cost — zero donut fund balance for September. The sign-in sheet could not be found, so there's no attendee list this time.

Stan, KM6VNI, demoed this huge battery box on a cart. Wow, Stan!



Inside Stan, KM6VNI's battery box. Photo by Ed Barnes, WA6ED.

Mike, KO6AOL, brought his HF rig setup for CW.



Mike, KO6AOL, with his HF rig setup for CW. Photo by Ed Barnes, WA6ED.

Greg, WE4BY, had a broken PowerPole on his battery — but it still works!



Close-up of the PowerPole connector on Greg, WE4BY's battery. Photo by Ed Barnes, WA6ED.

Brian, NJ6N, brought some interesting projects — one tracked aircraft on a little round display, and another was a PowerPole expander. It was a fun morning.



Members gather around a picnic table at Gilleran Park. Photo by Ed Barnes, WA6ED.

Next SOARA Saturday

- Date: Saturday, September 19, 2026
- Time: 9:00 AM-noon
- Location: Gilleran Park
- Theme: Digital modes (FreeDV and JS8Call workshop on HF planned; other digital and UHF/VHF modes welcome too)
- Donuts will be provided.

See the full announcement in this issue's Club News and Opportunities section for details and links.

73,

Ed, WA6ED

Club News and Opportunities

Next SOARA Saturday: Digital Modes at Gilleran Park

Ed Barnes, WA6ED, is giving members an early heads-up so they can get their equipment set up and bring it to the park.

What: SOARA Saturday — theme is digital modes. Several members are interested in a workshop for FreeDV and JS8Call on HF; this is a chance to test various modes and features. Other digital modes are welcome too, as well as UHF/VHF modes.

When: Saturday, September 19, 2026, 9:00 AM-noon

Where: Gilleran Park

Donuts will be provided. New to these modes? [JS8Call](#) and [FreeDV](#) are both good starting points.

73,

Ed, WA6ED

Recommended Links

A few links worth checking out this month:

- [I'm Obsessed With Local AI. Here's Why](#) Greg Isenberg (The Startup Ideas Podcast) explains local AI in plain terms -- running a model on hardware you control instead of the cloud -- and walks through the landscape of tools and terminology (parameters, tokens, context window, quantization, GGUF) for anyone getting started. Shared by Ed Barnes, WA6ED.
- [The Ham Ninja's Top 10 Safety Tips](#) Chris Claborne, N1CLC, draws on 880+ summit activations and his background as an Army medic, certified EMT, and private pilot to share ten safety tips for outdoor ham radio operations -- hydration, weather awareness, lightning safety, and navigation among them. Shared by Ray Frericks, K6NOV.

Battery Fire Follow-Up: What Went Wrong

During a recent Tuesday night VHF/UHF net, Mike Mahan, K6MSM, had to break off his transmission when a battery pack he was using caught fire — the incident Dale, W6EDT, mentioned in his President's Message elsewhere in this issue as a reminder to have a plan ready if a battery pack or its wiring catches fire. Mike followed up with the Board afterward with a closer look at what actually went wrong, in his own words, along with photos of the aftermath.

I placed four of these batteries in series to get a nice 12 volts. Everything was fine until I put the pack on a metal plate after cleaning out the ammo box that had held it overnight.

I believe my mistake was not realizing that the bottom of these batteries is the negative terminal as well. Doing this with one battery isn't an issue, but when the batteries are in series and I shorted the negative terminal of a battery down the line to the metal plate, the "magic" started. Since the batteries are in series, the negative terminal down the line wasn't at zero — so there was a voltage difference between the negative terminals. I think this ended up causing a short

through the negative terminals rather than the positive ones. If I'd placed the pack flat instead of resting the negative terminals on the metal plate, I suspect this wouldn't have happened. What does everyone think?



Bottom view of the four-cell pack. Each cell's case bottom is also its negative terminal — resting them on the metal plate is what created the short.

Photo by Mike Mahan, K6MSM.

Next time I run these in series — and some of these batteries might still be okay, I'll find out shortly — I'll make sure to tape the bottoms of the negatives so I don't get an unintentional short again.

I must have had the presence of mind to knock the pack onto its side to remove the short, which at least stopped the source of the fire.



Melted wiring and connectors at one end of the pack, on the scorched metal plate. Photo by Mike Mahan, K6MSM.



A burned-through hole in a nearby plastic lid gives a sense of how much heat the short generated. Photo by Mike Mahan, K6MSM.

Mike, K6MSM

Treasurer's Report

Eleven Months	August 2026	August 2025	Increase/(Decrease)
Cash Income:			
Memberships	\$8,339.00	\$9,871.00	\$(1,532.00)
Other & Interest	\$2,370.49	\$3,933.00	\$(1,562.51)
Total Cash Income	\$10,709.49	\$13,804.00	\$(3,094.51)
Cash Expenses:			
Repeaters incl. site rental, utilities & insurance	\$6,670.71	\$6,642.00	\$28.71
Member Activities	\$2,995.71	\$2,966.00	\$29.71
Other expenses	\$2,876.86	\$1,261.00	\$1,615.86
Total Cash Expenses	\$12,543.28	\$10,869.00	\$1,674.28
Cash Net Income	\$(1,833.79)	\$2,936.00	\$(4,768.79)
Beginning Cash — October 1	\$28,179.03	\$25,745.00	\$2,434.03
Ending Cash — August 31	\$26,345.24	\$28,681.00	\$(2,334.76)

If any member has questions about the financials, please contact the Treasurer or any Board member.

SOARA Information

Meetings: SOARA meets at the Norman P. Murray Center, 24932 Veterans Way, Mission Viejo, CA on the third Monday of every month at 6:30 PM. For January and February, the third Monday is a holiday and the meeting is held on the fourth Monday.

License Exams: Amateur license exams are given prior to SOARA meetings, except June. Exams are at 6:00 PM. Prior registration is not required and walk-in applicants are welcome. For June, exams are held at Field Day. For further information, email Steve Kuver, K6UVR, at k6uvr@soara.org.

SOARA Library: SOARA has many amateur radio related books such as handbooks, books about electrical theory, and more available to lend to club members. Contact library@soara.org for more information.

Web Site: SOARA maintains a web site with current club information at soara.org.

Repeaters

The Laguna Beach, San Clemente, and Trabuco repeaters are open. The Santiago Peak repeaters are closed. For details or questions on the repeaters, contact the repeater director at repeater@soara.org.

Band	Frequency	Shift	Tone / Notes	Location
2m	147.645	-	(110.9)	Laguna Beach
2m	146.025	+	(110.9)	San Clemente
2m	145.240	-	(110.9)	Trabuco
D-STAR 2m	146.115	+	(K6SOA C)	Laguna Beach
220	224.100	-	(110.9)	Laguna Beach
220	224.640	-	(pvt)	Santiago Peak (C)
440	445.660	-	(110.9)	Laguna Beach
D-STAR 440	445.705	-	(K6SOA B)	Laguna Beach
440	447.180	-	(pvt)	Santiago Peak (C)
D-STAR 1.2G	1282.600	-	(K6SOA A)	Laguna Beach

Nets

- 40 meter HF (7.200 MHz +/-): Sundays at 8:00 AM
- 10 meter HF (Technicians welcome) (28.415 +/-): Sundays at 9:00 AM
- General Membership Net — UHF/VHF (447.180, 147.645 & 224.640): Tuesdays at 8:00 PM

- D-STAR (146.115 C module): Wednesdays at 8:00 PM
- Tech Net — 147.645, 224.640, 447.180: Saturdays at 9:00 AM
- California Rescue Communications (Gordo Net) HF (7.250 MHz +/- for QRM): Weekdays at 8:30 AM
- MVRACES — 447.180: Tuesdays at 7:00 PM
- Tri-Cities RACES — 146.025: Wednesdays at 8:00 PM
- LNACS — 147.645: Thursdays at 7:00 PM
- OC Parks Fire Watch — 447.180: Thursdays at 8:00 PM

SOARA Officers

- **President:** Dale Tyler, W6EDT — w6edt@soara.org — 949-360-1717
- **Vice President:** Greg Unruh, WE4BY — we4by@soara.org
- **Secretary:** Charles Schultz, NY6I — ny6i@soara.org
- **Treasurer:** Ron Mosher, K0PGE — k0pge@soara.org — 949-363-0047

SOARA Directors

- **Repeater:** Open
- **Publications:** Ray Frericks, K6NOV — k6nov@soara.org
- **Membership:** Open
- **Education:** Steve Kuver, K6UVR — k6uvr@soara.org — 949-874-1972
- **Technical:** Tom Hobbs, AE6SH — ae6sh@soara.org — 949-887-6527
- **Communications:** Ray Hutchinson, AE6H — ae6h@soara.org

SOARA Appointments

- **Past President:** Ray Hutchinson, AE6H — ae6h@soara.org
- **Activities Coordinator:** Open
- **SOARA Saturdays:** Ed Barnes, WA6ED — wa6ed@soara.org — 949-468-7706
- **Raffle:** Open
- **Testing:** Steve Kuver, K6UVR — k6uvr@soara.org
- **Website:** Open

Contacting SOARA

Website: soara.org | Membership: membership@soara.org | Postal: P.O. Box 2545, Mission Viejo, CA 92690 | Facebook: K6SOA | Twitter/X: @K6SOA

Dates, locations, times, and frequencies are subject to change. Check the SOARA website before attending an event.

Questions about SOARA? membership@soara.org | P.O. Box 2545, Mission Viejo, CA 92690 | soara.org | Facebook/X: K6SOA